

“LOVE OF THE POOR IS LOVE OF GOD:” THE THEOLOGICAL FOUNDATIONS OF *DILEXI TE* IN THE PREFERENTIAL OPTION FOR THE POOR AND THOMISTIC *CARITAS*

Dr. Gigesh Meckal, TOR

Abstract

The article examines the claim “love of the poor is love of God” in Dilexi Te, drawing on two complementary traditions: the preferential option for the poor in liberation theology and Thomistic charity (caritas) as friendship with God. It argues that encountering the poor is encountering Christ, particularly as depicted in Scripture and Jesus’ identification with “the least,” and that care for the poor is constitutive of the Church’s identity and holiness. While liberation theology emphasizes the historical and revelatory priority of the poor as a privileged locus of God’s self-disclosure, Thomistic charity provides the metaphysical grounding, showing that love of neighbor flows intrinsically from communion with God. By integrating these approaches, the article demonstrates that merciful solidarity with the poor is both historically concrete and participatory in God’s love, presenting love for the poor as both practical solidarity and a form of communion with the divine.

Introduction

Pope Leo XIV’s *Dilexi Te*, issued at the outset of his pontificate, builds upon Pope Francis’ *Dilexit Nos* by addressing the Church’s care for the poor with the poignant declaration from Revelation: “I have loved you” (Rev 3:9; Dt 1, 3). This exhortation posits that Christ’s love is most vividly encountered in the marginalized, where “love for the Lord... is one with love for the poor” (Dt 5). The theme “love of the poor is love of God” is not merely ethical but revelatory, unveiling the heart of Christ and summoning believers to holiness through solidarity (Dt 3).

The exhortation’s title, evoking Christ’s address to the powerless community in Revelation (Dt 3), underscores that despite their “little power,” the poor are beloved. Pope Leo XIV thus establishes that there is close connection between Christ’s love and his summons to care for the poor (Dt 3). He cites *Gaudete et Exsultate*: “In this call to recognize him

in the poor and the suffering, we see revealed the very heart of Christ” (Dt 3).

The present study argues that the theological architecture of *Dilexi Te* becomes fully intelligible when read through two complementary interpretive lenses already operative within the Catholic tradition: the preferential option for the poor as articulated in liberation theology and the Thomistic doctrine of charity (*caritas*) understood as friendship (*amicitia*) with God. The former clarifies the concreteness of divine love; the latter provides its metaphysical and participatory grounding. Together, they disclose the inner coherence of the exhortation’s central thesis.

1. The Theme of Love for the Poor as Love of God in Dt

1.1. Encounter with the Poor as Encounter with Christ

The biblical narrative establishes love for the poor as inseparable from love for God, a theme Dt weaves throughout its exposition. In the Old Testament, God’s self-revelation emphasizes solidarity with the afflicted. The burning bush encounter is paradigmatic: “I have observed the misery of my people... I have heard their cry... I know their sufferings, and I have come down to deliver them... So come, I will send you” (Ex 3:7-8,10; Dt 8).

The New Testament brings this theme to eschatological climax in Jesus Christ, who embodies and proclaims God’s preferential love. The parable of the last judgment (Mt 25:31-46; Dt 28) provides the ultimate criterion: “Truly I tell you, just as you did it to one of the least of these who are members of my family, you did it to me” (Mt 25:40; Dt 5, 26). Acts of mercy — feeding the hungry, clothing the naked, visiting the sick and imprisoned — are not optional add-ons but constitutive of relationship with Christ. The exhortation stresses this without qualification: holiness cannot be lived “apart from these demands” (Dt 28).

Jesus unites the two great commandments: love God wholly and love neighbor as self (Mk 12:29-31; Deut 6:5; Lev 19:18; Dt 24). The Apostle John radicalizes this: “Those who do not love a brother or sister whom they have seen, cannot love God whom they have not seen” (1 Jn 4:20; Dt 24). Refusal to help the needy reveals absence of God’s love (1 Jn 3:17; Dt 30). James challenges empty faith: “If a brother or sister is naked and lacks daily food, and one of you says to them, ‘Go in peace; keep warm and eat your fill,’ and yet you do not supply their bodily needs, what is the

good of that? So faith by itself, if it has no works, is dead” (Jas 2:15-17; Dt 29).

In the poor, he continues to speak to us (Dt 5). The poor are ever-present (Mt 26:11; Dt 4-5), yet his presence endures (Mt 28:20; Dt 5).

Jesus’ words link perpetual presence of the poor with his own abiding presence: “You always have the poor with you, but you will not always have me” (Mt 26:11; Dt 4-5), yet “I am with you always” (Mt 28:20; Dt 5). The poor thus become the ongoing locus of encounter with the risen Lord.

Theologically, these texts reveal God’s merciful love as descent into poverty (Dt 16), fulfilled in Christ. Love for the poor is thus revelation: “Contact with those who are lowly and powerless is a fundamental way of encountering the Lord” (Dt 5). Wanting to inaugurate a kingdom of justice, fraternity and solidarity, God has a special place in his heart for those who are discriminated against and oppressed, and he asks us, his Church, to make a decisive and radical choice in favor of the weakest (Dt 16). In hearing their cry, we enter God’s heart (Dt 8), making biblical foundations the bedrock for Christological and ecclesial developments. In hearing the cry of the poor, we are asked to enter into the heart of God, who is always concerned for the needs of his children, especially those in greatest need. If we remain unresponsive to that cry, the poor might well cry out to the Lord against us, and we would incur guilt (cf. Deut 15:9) and turn away from the very heart of God (Dt 8).

1.2. Christological Kenosis and the Poor Messiah

At the heart of Dt lies a profoundly Christocentric vision: Jesus Christ is not merely a teacher of mercy toward the poor but the very embodiment of God’s preferential love who “became poor” to enrich us (2 Cor 8:9; Dt 18). The exhortation presents Jesus as the “poor Messiah” and the “Messiah of and for the poor” (Dt 19), whose entire existence — from incarnation to passion — reveals divine solidarity with human weakness and exclusion. This Christology is rooted in the mystery of the *kenosis* (self-emptying) described by Saint Paul: “You know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, so that by his poverty you might become rich” (2 Cor 8:9; Dt 18). Here, Christ’s poverty is not accidental but missional: it is the means by which God fully reveals divine love (cf. Jn 1:18; 1 Jn 4:9; Dt 18) and accomplishes salvation.

The exhortation frames this *kenosis* within the broader plan of God’s merciful love, which “unfolds and is fulfilled in history” through descent “among us to free us from slavery, fear, sin and the power of death” (Dt 16). His *kenosis* — “emptied himself, taking the form of a slave” (Phil 2:7; Dt 18) — reveals God’s plan: by assuming human nature in its fragility. God addresses poverty in its radical form. Jesus “became poor and was born in the flesh like us,” sharing “the limitations and fragility of our human nature” (Dt 16). This culminates in the extreme humiliation of the cross, where he experiences “radical poverty, which is death” (Dt 16). Theologically, this self-emptying (Phil 2:7: “he emptied himself, taking the form of a slave, being born in human likeness”; Dt 18) is the archetype of divine compassion: God does not remain aloof but enters the condition of the oppressed to liberate them.

Jesus’ earthly life bears witness to this poverty from the beginning. The Nativity narrative in Luke poignantly notes that “there was no place for them in the inn” (Lk 2:7; Dt 19), with the newborn laid in a manger — a feeding trough for animals — symbolizing exclusion from human hospitality. This rejection continues: to escape Herod’s massacre, the Holy Family flees as refugees to Egypt (Mt 2:13-15; Dt 19). At the dawn of his public ministry, after proclaiming the fulfillment of Isaiah’s prophecy in Nazareth — “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to bring good news to the poor” (Lk 4:18; cf. Is 61:1; Dt 21) — Jesus is driven out of town and nearly killed (Lk 4:28-30; Dt 19). His ministry ends in crucifixion outside the city walls (Mk 15:22; Dt 19), as an outcast executed among criminals. This pattern of rejection mirrors the lot of the poor and marginalized in every age: exclusion, displacement, and death at society’s margins.

The exhortation connects these elements to the parable of the last judgment (Mt 25:31-46; Dt 28), where the criterion of salvation is mercy shown to the hungry, thirsty, stranger, naked, sick, and imprisoned: “Just as you did it to one of the least of these who are members of my family, you did it to me” (Mt 25:40; Dt 5, 26). This is no metaphor but revelation: the poor are Christ’s sacramental presence in history. The anointing at Bethany (Mt 26:6-13; Dt 4) illustrates the tension and unity: while the disciples criticize the “waste” of expensive ointment that could aid the poor, Jesus affirms both his impending death and the perpetual presence of the poor (Mt 26:11). Yet he links them inseparably: the poor remain as the ongoing locus of his presence (cf. Mt 28:20; Dt 5).

Theologically, preferential option is God's compassion for humanity's weakness (Dt 16), not exclusive but emphasizing oppressed for justice, fraternity (Dt 16). Jesus confirms dignity in weakness (Dt 2), inspiring liberation (Dt 2). Love for poor is love for Christ, who speaks through them (Dt 5). By contemplating Jesus as the poor Messiah, the Church discerns its own vocation: to be poor with the poor, to walk in solidarity, and to proclaim God's love precisely where it is most needed. In the faces of the suffering, the Church encounters the crucified and risen Lord (Dt 52, 58, 90), whose "I have loved you" (Rev 3:9; Dt 1, 3) continues to echo through history.

1.3. Ecclesial Identity and Holiness in Solidarity with the Poor

The Church's two-millennia history bears eloquent witness to the truth that love of the poor is love of God, manifesting in concrete acts of charity, institutional service, and prophetic critique. As DT affirms, "there is an inseparable bond between our faith and the poor" (Dt 36), and the poor are recognized as bearing "the likeness of [the Church's] poor and suffering founder" (Dt 36). This tradition is not peripheral but constitutive of ecclesial identity: the Church is called to identify with the least, making care for them an essential expression of fidelity to Christ.

From the earliest days, the nascent Christian community integrated service to the poor into its core life. Despite few members being "wise according to the flesh, not many powerful, not many of noble birth" (1 Cor 1:26; Dt 37), the apostles responded to the needs of widows by instituting the order of deacons for the *diakonia* (service) of tables and the poor (Acts 6:1-5; Dt 37). Stephen, the first deacon and first martyr, unites witness to faith through proclamation and through concrete care for the marginalized (Dt 37), showing that martyrdom and charity are inseparable.

By the third century, Saint Lawrence, deacon of Rome under Pope Sixtus II, dramatizes this reality. When Roman authorities demanded the Church's treasures, Lawrence presented the poor, declaring, "These are the treasures of the Church" (Dt 38). Saint Ambrose's account poses the rhetorical question: "What treasures does Jesus have that are more precious than those in which he loves to show himself?" (Dt 38). This episode redefines ecclesial wealth: not gold or vessels, but human persons in whom Christ is present.

In the East, Saint John Chrysostom stands as a towering voice for social justice. In his homilies, he insists: “Do you wish to honor the body of Christ? Do not allow it to be despised in its members, that is, in the poor... Do not honor Christ’s body here in church with silk fabrics, while outside you neglect it when it suffers from cold and nakedness” (Dt 41). He links Eucharist and ethics: “What advantage does Christ gain if the sacrificial table is laden with golden vessels, while he himself dies of hunger in the person of the poor? Feed the hungry first, and only afterward adorn the altar with what remains” (Dt 41). For Chrysostom, the Eucharist is a sacramental prolongation of charity: true worship demands justice preceding and accompanying it.

In the West, Saint Augustine of Hippo taught that ecclesial communion includes communion of goods. In his commentaries on the Psalms, he urges charity toward strangers if Christ dwells within (Dt 44). The poor are not mere recipients but the sacramental presence of the Lord: Augustine places words in Christ’s mouth regarding almsgiving: “I received the earth, I will give heaven... The bread you have given to my poor has been consumed, but the bread I will give will not only refresh you, but will never end” (Dt 45). Almsgiving purifies the giver and erases sins when accompanied by amendment (Dt 46; cf. Pseudo-Augustine). Augustine’s vision illuminates the poor as essential to Christ’s living Body.

Monastic life, born in the desert, witnessed to solidarity from its origins. Monks and nuns renounced wealth not merely through contemptus mundi but to encounter the poor Christ in radical detachment. Saint Basil the Great’s Rule integrates prayer and labor for the needy: monks must work diligently “to have enough to help the needy... profitable not only for subduing the body, but also for charity towards our neighbor” (Dt 53).

Saint Benedict of Nursia placed welcoming the poor and pilgrims at the heart of community life: “The poor and pilgrims are to be received with all care and hospitality, for it is in them that Christ is received” (Dt 55).

The mendicant orders radicalized this imitation. Saint Francis of Assisi became the icon of evangelical poverty, embracing the leper as Christ (Dt 6) and mandating in his Rule that brothers live as pilgrims, begging without shame because “the Lord made himself poor for us” (Dt 64).

Francis' poverty was relational: he became lesser, neighbor, brother to the poor (Dt 64, 67).

The Second Vatican Council represented a decisive shift. Saint John XXIII presented the Church as "of the poor" (Dt 84), while Cardinal Lercaro described the mystery of Christ present in the poor as "in some sense the only theme of the Council" (Dt 84). Saint Paul VI affirmed the poor as universal representatives of Christ, even likening their representation to that of the Pope (Dt 85).

Latin American episcopal conferences — Medellín (Dt 90), Puebla, and especially Aparecida (Dt 99) — rooted the option in faith in the God who "became poor for us" (Dt 99).

Across centuries — from apostolic *diakonia* to the contemporary preferential option — this unbroken tradition discloses the Church's core vocation: to be poor and for the poor (Dt 35), constantly renewed by recognizing Christ in the suffering (Dt 103).

The exhortation ties the preferential option directly to the universal call to holiness. It insists that "in this call to recognize him in the poor and the suffering, we see revealed the very heart of Christ, his deepest feelings and choices, which every saint seeks to imitate" (Dt 3). Holiness cannot be understood or lived "apart from these demands" of mercy (Dt 28).

Specific dimensions of poverty receive theological emphasis:

- Migration: Christ Himself "came to what was his own, and his own people did not accept him" (Jn 1:11), living as a stranger. The Church recognizes in migrants "a living presence of the Lord" who will say, "I was a stranger and you welcomed me" (Mt 25:35; Dt 73).
- The Sick and Suffering: Care for the ill is an ecclesial action through which members "touch the suffering flesh of Christ" (Dt 49). Healing a wound proclaims that "the Kingdom of God begins among the most vulnerable" (Dt 52).

Dt illuminates that love of the poor is love of God, a path to holiness renewing all (Dt 121). Christ's "I have loved you" echoes in their lives, summoning us to solidarity.

While Dt situates the theme within Scripture and tradition, contemporary theology has offered conceptual clarifications that sharpen its meaning.

Liberation theology, in particular, articulates the preferential dimension of this love.

2. The Preferential Love for the Poor: The Liberation Theological Framework

2.1. The Poor as Privileged Locus of Divine Self-Disclosure

Within contemporary Catholic theology, the preferential option for the poor (POP) emerges not as a secondary ethical concern but as a theological claim about God and about the nature of Christian discipleship. In liberation theology, this option articulates the intrinsic unity between love of God and solidarity with the poor. The foundations of this position are laid with particular clarity by Gustavo Gutiérrez and Jon Sobrino, whose theological reflections frame preferential love as participation in God’s own self-revelation and saving action.

For liberation theology, the option for the poor is first and foremost theological rather than political. It asserts that genuine love for God is realized concretely in solidarity with those who are impoverished and marginalized. The option is not reducible to paternalistic assistance or episodic benevolence. Rather, it demands identification with the poor and their historical struggle.¹ It is grounded in faith in the God whose gratuitous love manifests itself preferentially among the least.

Gutiérrez repeatedly insists that the option arises from revelation itself. God’s love, he argues, “is revealed to the poor”; they are those who receive, understand, and proclaim this love. This revelation is constitutive of Christian faith.² A deep and authentic sense of God “is not only not opposed to a sensitivity to the poor and their social world, but it is ultimately lived only in those persons and that world.”³ The poor are not passive recipients of charity but subjects of history and agents of liberation. In them, Gutiérrez declares, “the Lord will save history.”⁴ Thus, solidarity with the poor is not external to the knowledge of God; it is the locus in which God is encountered and confessed.

This theological grounding clarifies the inner logic of the option. If God’s self-disclosure is historically situated among the poor, then love of God

1 Gustavo Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1988), xxviii.

2 Ibid., 105.

3 Ibid., 203.

4 Ibid., 53.

cannot be abstracted from concrete commitment to their dignity. The option is therefore not an optional strategy but a constitutive dimension of faith.

2.2. Incarnation, Kenosis, and Historical Solidarity

The Christological warrant for the POP lies in the mystery of the Incarnation. Just as the Son of God “became poor,”⁵ so must disciples embrace poverty in some real and effective way if they are to share Christ’s solidarity. The *kenosis* of Christ grounds and norms Christian praxis. To encounter the poor is to encounter the Lord; “an act of love towards them is an act of love towards God.”⁶ Biblical revelation confirms this inseparability: authentic worship of God cannot be severed from solidarity with the poor.⁷

Sobrino deepens the christological dimension by emphasizing the epistemological privilege of the poor. Engagement with them discloses the depth of God’s kenosis: God makes himself other, immerses himself in history, and renders credible his definitive word of love.⁸ Through identification with the poor, believers participate in this divine movement. God is encountered not outside history but within its wounds. In this sense, the poor mediate revelation; they become the privileged locus where divine love is discerned and enacted.

2.3. Ecclesial Reception: From Latin American Theology to Universal Magisterium

Although born in Latin American contexts, the POP has been integrated into universal Catholic teaching as a foundational principle of social doctrine. It is described as a “special form of primacy in the exercise of Christian charity.”⁹ The option bridges evangelization and social justice, rooting both in the primacy of charity.

Pope John Paul II played a decisive role in articulating this integration. During visits to Mexico and Brazil, he spoke of the poor as God’s favorites and invoked Christ’s incarnation among them.¹⁰ By 1986, he

5 Ibid., 172.

6 Ibid., 115.

7 Ibid., 125.

8 Jon Sobrino, *The True Church and the Poor*, trans. Matthew J. O’Connell (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1984), 33.

9 John Paul II, *Encyclical Letter Sollicitudo rei Socialis*, no. 42. Hereafter SRS.

10 John Paul II, “Address to the Indians of Oaxaca and Chiapas,” in *Puebla and Beyond: Documentation and Commentary*, eds. John Eagleson and Philip Scharper (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1979), 82.

explicitly affirmed the POP as “the choice of the Gospel,” identifying it as Christ’s own option. To choose the poor is to choose Christ; the two are inseparable in every century and context.¹¹ In *Sollicitudo Rei Socialis* (no. 47), he called the Church to discern Christ’s voice in the cry of the poor, while *Centesimus Annus* linked the option to the continuity of *Rerum Novarum* and extended it to cultural and spiritual poverty (no. 58). In *Novo Millennio Ineunte*, the option was presented as programmatic for the new millennium, placing charity — especially charity toward the poor — at the center of ecclesial renewal.¹²

This magisterial development underscores the soteriological dimension of the option. Salvation is holistic, embracing material and spiritual liberation. Grounded in the anthropology of the Second Vatican Council, which affirms the dignity of every human person as image of God, the POP demands preferential engagement with those whose dignity is most gravely threatened. It witnesses to the Church’s two-millennia tradition of creative and resourceful charity (SRS, no. 42).¹³

At the Fifth General Assembly of CELAM in Aparecida (2007), Pope Benedict XVI affirmed that the POP is implicit in Christological faith in the God who became poor for us (cf. 2 Cor 8:9).¹⁴ Divine poverty becomes the archetype for human charity. The kenotic movement of Christ, who enriches humanity through his poverty, grounds preferential love. The option thus emerges not as sociological strategy but as consequence of faith in the Incarnate Word.

Pope Francis further deepened this theological articulation by describing poverty as a “theological” category — the “first category” — because the Son of God abased himself and became poor in order to walk with humanity. Poverty mirrors the Incarnation; it is the historical form in which divine self-abasement is encountered.¹⁵ Service to the poor is therefore service to Christ himself, echoing the criterion of judgment in Matthew 25.

Francis insists that reaching out to the poor means reaching out to the suffering flesh of Jesus. Those who suffer, even without explicit theological

11 John Paul II, Address to the Comunitadi S. Egidio (Dec. 14, 1986), in *L’osservatore Romano*, Dec. 15, 1986, at 6-8.

12 John Paul II, *Novo Millennio Ineunte*, nos. 49-50.

13 Also in *Gaudium et Spes*, no. 1.

14 Benedict XVI, “Address at the Inaugural Session of the Fifth General Conference of CELAM” (May 13, 2007).

15 Francis, “Address at the Vigil of Pentecost with Ecclesial Movements” (May 18, 2013).

awareness, bear Christ's presence.¹⁶ The "poor holy people of God" are not passive recipients of assistance but sources of religious experience. They share in the *sensus fidei* and know the suffering Christ in their difficulties. The Church must allow herself to be evangelized by them. The new evangelization requires recognizing the saving power at work in their lives and placing them at the center of the Church's pilgrimage.¹⁷ Hence Francis calls for a "poor Church for the poor."

This development does not alter the theological core articulated by liberation theology; rather, it confirms and universalizes it. Preferential love for the poor is inseparable from ecclesial identity. Charity, understood ontologically as participation in God's own love, becomes concrete in solidarity with those who embody Christ's poverty.

The theological coherence of the POP lies in its Christological grounding. The God who reveals himself in *kenosis* makes divine love historically accessible in poverty. Therefore, to love the poor is to participate in the divine movement by which God enters history and sides with the afflicted. The option reveals that love of God cannot remain abstract or disincarnate. It must assume historical form.¹⁸

Liberation theology thus provides a conceptual framework in which the affirmation that "love of the poor is love of God" becomes intelligible. Solidarity with the poor is not an ethical supplement to worship; it is the concrete enactment of faith in the Incarnate Lord. Through identification with the marginalized, believers encounter God, participate in divine *kenosis*, and become instruments of the liberation that God intends for all.¹⁹

Thus, liberation theology clarifies the preferential dimension already present in DT: love of the poor is not accidental but revelatory. Yet to grasp fully how such love is participation in divine life itself, a further doctrinal grounding is required. That grounding is found in the Thomistic doctrine of charity.

16 Francis, "Address to Participants in the Ecclesial Convention of the Diocese of Rome" (June 17, 2013).

17 Francis, *Apostolic Exhortation Evangelii Gaudium*, no. 28.

18 Martin Schlag, "The Preferential Option for the Poor and Catholic Social Teaching," in *Catholic Social Teaching: A Volume of Scholarly Essays*, pp. 468-482 (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2019), 472.

19 Benedict XVI, *Encyclical letter Deus caritas est (On Christian love)*, no. 25.

3. Charity as Friendship with God: The Thomistic Foundation of DT

St. Thomas Aquinas provides the philosophical architecture for this theme by defining charity (*caritas*) as friendship (*amicitia*) with God. At the doctrinal center of Thomas Aquinas’ moral and spiritual theology stands a claim of decisive importance: charity (*caritas*) is friendship (*amicitia*) with God.

3.1. Aristotelian Foundations: Friendship as the Matrix of Charity

Scholars have long observed Aquinas’ profound indebtedness to Aristotle, especially Book VIII of the *Nicomachean Ethics*.²⁰ Aristotle opens his treatment of friendship (*philia*) by declaring it indispensable to a fully human life. The highest form — friendship of virtue or character — requires mutual benevolence, reciprocal love, and a shared life grounded in some form of commonality (*koinōnia*). The friend is described as “another self” (NE VIII.7 [1159a4–5]), and friendship entails concord (*homonoia*), shared choice, and participation in one another’s joys and sorrows.

Aquinas explicitly cites Aristotle on the intrinsic relation between friendship and virtue (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 3, ad 1). He also notes Aristotle’s remark that the friendship of children to parents and of human beings to the gods is a friendship directed toward what is good and superior.²¹ Yet Aristotle himself appears to regard this latter form as attenuated (NE VIII.7 [1159a4–5]). The paradigm remains the robust reciprocity of morally equal friends, whose common life manifests shared excellence and deliberate choice.

This Aristotelian paradigm provides Aquinas with both conceptual resources and a set of tensions. On the one hand, friendship requires benevolence, mutuality, and common life; on the other, the infinite inequality between God and human beings seems to preclude the equality necessary for perfect friendship. Aquinas does not abandon Aristotle’s framework in the face of this difficulty. Rather, he reconstitutes it within a supernatural horizon.

In *Summa Theologiae* II–II, q. 27, a. 2, Aquinas cites five marks of friendship: willing the good of the other, wishing the other to exist and live, sharing life (*convivere*), choosing the same things, and rejoicing and

20 Hereafter NE.

21 Jonathan Canary, “Transforming Friendship: Thomas Aquinas on Charity as Friendship with God,” *Irish Theological Quarterly* 85 (2020): 4.

sorrowing together (ST II-II, q. 27, a. 2). More fundamentally, in ST II-II, q. 23, a. 1, he sets out the three essential elements derived from Aristotle: (1) benevolence (*benevolentia*), by which one desires the good of the other for the other's sake; (2) mutual love (*mutua amatio*); and (3) some form of sharing (*aliqua communicatio*), grounding a common life. Friendship is further marked by concord (*concordia*) (ST II-II, q. 29, a. 3).

When Aquinas asks directly whether charity is a kind of friendship (ST II-II, q. 23, a. 1), he does so by engaging Aristotle's criteria head-on. The three *sed contra* arguments in that article are drawn from Book VIII of the *Ethics*, and Aquinas answers them without relinquishing the Aristotelian structure. The first objection concerns the necessity of common life: how can invisible God and corporeal humanity share life? Aquinas responds that the common life in question is spiritual. Even now believers have their *conversatio* in heaven (Phil 3:20), and this communion will be perfected in the beatific vision (Rev 22:4).²² He later adds that the Eucharist, in its visible form, fulfills the requirement that friends live together, signifying and effecting supreme charity (ST II-II, q. 75, a. 1).

The second objection recalls that friendship requires reciprocity, whereas charity extends even to enemies. Aquinas answers by distinguishing between loving a friend directly and loving what belongs to the friend. In loving God, one loves those who belong to God — even enemies — *in ordine ad Deum*. Thus the extension of charity beyond reciprocity does not negate friendship but radicalizes it within a theocentric order.²³

The decisive move appears in Aquinas' commentary on the *Ethics*, composed roughly contemporaneously with the *Secunda Pars*. There he acknowledges Aristotle's observation that when parties are "very distant, as men are from God, there no longer remains such friendship about which we are now speaking."²⁴ At the level of nature, the inequality is indeed too great. Yet this judgment holds only within a purely natural order. When God communicates grace and conforms human beings to himself, and when God becomes man in Christ (ST III, q. 1, a. 3), a new mode of

22 Guy Mansini, "Aristotle and Aquinas' Theology of Charity in the *Summa Theologiae*," in *Aristotle in Aquinas' Theology*, eds. Gilles Emery and Matthew Levering (New York: Oxford University Press, 2015), 127.

23 *Ibid.*, 127.

24 *Sententia Libri Ethicorum* VIII, lect. 7 (no. 1635).

equality — an equality of participation — emerges. The equality requisite for friendship thus becomes one of the *convenientiae* of the Incarnation.²⁵

Accordingly, in ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1, Aquinas reformulates Aristotle’s definition in explicitly theological terms. Friendship requires *amor amicitiae* rather than *amor concupiscentiae*; it must be mutual; and it must rest on some commonality.²⁶ That commonality is supplied by God’s sharing of his own beatitude with humanity. Aquinas invokes 1 Corinthians 1:9 — “God is faithful, through whom you have been called into the society (*societas*) of his Son” — to identify the shared good that grounds this friendship (cf. ST I–II, q. 51, a. 4; q. 62, aa. 1, 3). Charity is the created *habitus* infused by God that renders this mutual benevolence possible (ST II–II, q. 24, a. 2). It presupposes a developed anthropology of the will, since friendship requires the genuine exercise of two distinct wills in reciprocal love.²⁷

Later thinkers such as John Duns Scotus objected that the inequality between God and humanity prevents charity from being friendship in the strict Aristotelian sense; for Scotus, charity is similar to or more perfect than friendship, but not identical with it.²⁸ Aquinas, by contrast, maintains that once the supernatural order of grace is taken into account, charity genuinely fulfills the Aristotelian criteria. In so doing, he simultaneously adopts and subverts Aristotle. He retains the conceptual grammar of friendship while rejecting its limitation to politically free and socially equal men of virtue. Through charity, God befriends every human being.²⁹ As Young observes, charity thus surpasses Aristotelian friendship both “vertically,” by elevating it to transcendent communion with God, and “horizontally,” by opening new possibilities of friendship within humanity.³⁰

Although Aquinas’ synthesis is distinctive, he was not the first Christian thinker to explore the theological implications of friendship. In the twelfth century, earlier monastic reticence gave way to more explicit reflection on spiritual friendship and its relation to divine love.

25 Mansini, “Aristotle and Aquinas’ Theology of Charity,” 128.

26 Ibid., 124.

27 Ibid., “Aristotle and Aquinas’ Theology of Charity,” 137.

28 John Duns Scotus, *Ordinatio* III, dist. 27, a. un., nos. 68–69.

29 William W. Young III, *The Politics of Praise: Naming God and Friendship in Aquinas and Derrida* (Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2007), 136.

30 Canary, “Transforming Friendship,” 4.

Bernard of Clairvaux emphasized affective love and desire in the relationship with God and with the brethren. His mystical theology of union with God directly informed his account of human friendship. The two loves were not conceived as rivals but as mutually illuminating dimensions of a single movement toward communion.³¹

An even more decisive development occurs in the work of Aelred of Rievaulx. In *Spiritual Friendship* and the *Mirror of Charity*, Aelred offers a thorough Christian adaptation of Cicero's *De Amicitia*.³² Only virtuous and sanctified friendship merits the name, yet such friendship may be intimate, particular, and profound. Crucially, Aelred presents human friendship as a pathway to God. In *Spiritual Friendship* 2.14, he describes how a friend praying for a friend may find love for the friend passing imperceptibly into love for Christ, until the sweetness of Christ is tasted directly. Ascending from holy love of the friend to love of Christ, the believer anticipates the fullness of communion in the life to come.

Here the trajectory runs from human friendship upward to divine communion. When Aquinas addresses *caritas*, many of Aelred's themes reappear — particularly the language of friendship and mutual delight. Yet Aquinas reverses the direction. The *sed contra* of ST II-II, q. 23, a. 1 cites John 15:15 — "I will not call you servants, but my friends" — and concludes that this is said by reason of charity. From this scriptural datum Aquinas begins not with human friendship as an analogy for divine love, but with divine friendship as the primary reality: "charity is a certain friendship of man with God." The methodological shift is significant. For Aquinas, the friendship with God is not the terminus reached by ascending from human friendship; it is the supernatural principle that grounds and transforms all human friendships.

A similar, though less developed, connection appears in Hugh of St. Victor. In *De sacramentis* 2.13.11, Hugh identifies friendship (citing Prov 17:17) as a form of love and therefore of *caritas*. Yet the remark is incidental, emerging in the context of a discussion of whether charity can be lost. Hugh does not elaborate a systematic theology of charity as friendship. Aquinas' integration of Aristotelian friendship into the doctrine of the infused theological virtue therefore marks a genuine advance beyond his predecessors.³³

31 Ibid., 15.

32 Ibid., 6.

33 Ibid., 8.

The pre-Thomistic tradition thus supplied Aquinas with a rich repertoire. What Aquinas adds is a rigorous philosophical architecture.

3.2. Caritas as Amicitia: Participation in the Divine Life

Aquinas conceives of charity as grace-inspired friendship with God and the love of all other persons “in God” (ST II–II, q. 25, a. 1). From the outset of his treatise on charity in the *Secunda Secundae*, he poses a revealing question: whether charity is friendship (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1). Rather than beginning with charity as simply an infused virtue, Aquinas situates it within the richer relational framework of *amicitia*. This methodological decision foregrounds reciprocity, participation, and shared life as essential to the theological virtue (ST II–II, q. 47, a. 2).

Aquinas defines charity explicitly as “a friendship of a person for God” (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1). The principal act of charity is to love rather than to be loved (ST II–II, q. 27, a. 1). Yet its fullest expression consists in *amor amicitiae*, the love of friendship. Charity is not reducible to benevolence, philanthropy, or altruism. It is a divinely established communion in which God and the human person share life together.

This framing is decisive. Friendship entails more than affective inclination. It presupposes choice (*electio*), mutual awareness, and some form of shared life (*societas*). By identifying charity with friendship, Aquinas affirms that the divine–human relationship involves genuine reciprocity grounded in grace. As Guy Mansini notes, Aquinas retrieves and transforms the classical account of friendship in order to articulate the theological reality of charity within the structure of mutual love.³⁴

To understand Aquinas’ claim, one must first attend to his analysis of love (*amor*). Love signifies the appetite’s resting in the beloved. The passion of love (*amatio*) indicates fervor and affective movement. Friendship (*amicitia*), however, perfects these by adding two decisive elements: shared life and reciprocal love. It is not enough to wish another well; friendship requires that each be friendly in return (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1). Moreover, friendship involves concord in desire and deliberate choice informed by intellect.

In his commentary on the *Sentences*, Aquinas observes that friendship is “the most perfect among all the things that pertain to love.” This perfection

³⁴ Ibid., 130.

lies in its mutuality and its rootedness in shared good. Charity, accordingly, is not loosely analogous to friendship. It is “a kind of friendship of man to God through which man loves God and God loves man,” resulting in genuine association (*societas*) between them.³⁵ As Stephen Pope emphasizes, the divine–human relationship is analogous to friendship precisely through God’s free and forgiving self-communication.³⁶

Yet this identification raises a difficulty. Classical accounts of friendship presuppose proportional equality. If affection is to be reciprocal, it must be proportionate (cf. NE 8.7 [1158b]). How, then, can there be friendship between Creator and creature? As Jonathan Kanary observes, how could any human love equal or surpass the love of God?

Aquinas confronts this challenge directly. Charity, he insists, “hyper-exceeds the proportion of human nature” and depends not upon natural virtue but upon the grace of the Holy Spirit (ST II–II, q. 24, a. 3). The equality required for friendship is not natural but gifted. God’s initiative establishes what William Young describes as a “derivative equality” between God and humanity.³⁷ The friendship is real not because the ontological disproportion disappears, but because grace elevates the creature into a new order of participation (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 2; ST I–II, q. 65, a. 4).

3.3. Grace, Freedom, and Reciprocal Love

The initiative in charity belongs entirely to God. Echoing 1 John 4:19, Aquinas affirms that human beings love God only because God first loves them. Divine grace does not override freedom but enables it. “It is necessary that the will be moved by the Holy Spirit toward loving in this way — that the will itself also bring about this act” (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 2). The will remains a true secondary cause, freely eliciting acts of love under the motion of grace.

Aquinas reinforces this point by invoking Augustine’s maxim: “He who created you without you will not justify you without you” (ST I–II, q. 65, a. 4). The reciprocity of friendship therefore presupposes real agency.

35 Thomas Aquinas, *III Sententiarum*, d. 27, q. 2, a. 1, corpus.

36 Stephen J. Pope, ‘The Order of Love and Recent Catholic Ethics: A Constructive Proposal’, *Theological Studies* 52 (1991): 258.

37 Young, *The Politics of Praise*, 102.

Human beings are not passive instruments in divine friendship; they are active participants whose wills are healed and elevated by grace.

Charity is thus an infused virtue of the will (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 2). God causes in the human person a love that moves the will freely toward himself through participation in divine likeness (ST I, q. 43, a. 5). As Daria Spezzano observes, this participation deifies the will, conforming it to God’s own willing.³⁸ Friends share the same likes and dislikes (ST II–II, q. 104, a. 4). Accordingly, charity unites the human will with the divine will (ST I–II, q. 19, a. 10).

The structure of charity is therefore irreducibly relational. It is sustained by grace, structured by reciprocity (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1), and perfected in participation in divine life.

The reciprocity of charity is grounded metaphysically in participation. Aquinas repeatedly employs the language of communication and sharing to describe the divine–human relationship. Charity unites the soul immediately to God “with a chain (*vinculo*) of spiritual union” (ST II–II, q. 27, a. 4). In friendship-love, the friends arrive at “mutual inherence” (*mutua inhaesio*) (ST I–II, q. 28, a. 2).

Human beings are already metaphysically rooted in God through participation in being.³⁹ Yet grace transcends this natural participation. Through charity, the human person becomes *deiformis*.⁴⁰ “It is necessary that God alone should deify, communicating a sharing of the divine nature through a certain participation of likeness” (ST I–II, q. 112, a. 1). This is not absorption into divinity but elevation by likeness.

This participatory framework is inseparable from Aquinas’ understanding of the *imago Dei*. As Robert Barron explains, the human person is drawn toward God as final end because the divine image is inscribed within.⁴¹ Jean-Pierre Torrell similarly emphasizes that the image is ordered to its exemplar and thus tends toward union.⁴² Charity perfects this dynamism by uniting the image to its source.

38 Daria Spezzano, ““Be Imitators of God” (Eph 5:1): Aquinas on Charity and Satisfaction,” *Nova et Vetera* 15 (2017): 640.

39 Anthony T. Flood, *The Metaphysical Foundations of Love* (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 2018), xiii, 44ff.

40 Ibid., 56; Kauth, *Charity as Divine and Human Friendship*, 46–49.

41 Robert Barron, *Thomas Aquinas: Spiritual Master* (New York: Crossroad, 1996), 155f.

42 Jean-Pierre Torrell, *Saint Thomas Aquinas: Spiritual Master*, vol. 2 (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 2003), 82.

Aidan Nichols underscores that the Trinity dwells in the justified through grace.⁴³ The triune God is communion of perfect reciprocal love.⁴⁴ Charity therefore configures believers to a Trinitarian pattern of self-giving. Fergus Kerr captures this dynamic by noting that we image God most fully in the “event” of knowing and loving.⁴⁵ Charity is thus not static possession but living participation.

In this light, charity is both friendship founded upon God’s communication of beatitude (ST II-II, q. 23, a. 1; q. 24, a. 2) and a theological virtue ordering the will toward divine communion (ST II-II q. 23, a.2). Participation deifies, conforms, and unites. The disproportion between Creator and creature is not erased but bridged by grace (ST I-II, q.19, a.10). Friends share the same likes and dislikes (ST II-II, q.104, a.4).

3.4. Charity as Supernatural Friendship and Participation in Divine Beatitude

Aquinas begins from the classical insight that friendship requires mutual love and goodwill grounded in some shared good. Charity qualifies as true friendship only because God has first willed to communicate his blessedness to creatures (ST II-II, q. 24, a. 2). The scriptural warrant is decisive. The *sed contra* of ST II-II, q. 23, a. 1 cites John 15:15: “I will not now call you servants, but my friends.” The *corpus* appeals to 1 Corinthians 1:9, which speaks of being called into the *societas* of God’s Son. Friendship with God is therefore not metaphorical but grounded in divine initiative.

This *communicatio* is not a natural exchange of goods between equals but a supernatural participation. Those who possess charity do so “only by an infusion of the Holy Spirit” (ST II-II, q. 24, a. 2). The shared good is nothing less than the love that eternally unites the Father and the Son — the Holy Spirit himself.⁴⁶ Charity is thus participation in intra-Trinitarian love, extended outward by the free decision of the divine will. As Fergus Kerr observes, the “happiness” that constitutes humanity’s ultimate end is nothing other than sharing in God’s own life.⁴⁷ Similarly, Mary Ann Fatula

43 Aidan Nichols, *Discovering Aquinas* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 63.

44 Ibid., 56.

45 Fergus Kerr, *After Aquinas* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2002), 127–28.

46 Robert Miner, “Thomas Aquinas and Hans Urs von Balthasar: A Dialogue on Love and Charity,” *New Blackfriars* 95 (2014): 509.

47 Kerr, *After Aquinas*, 118.

describes the Christian life as an evolving partnership in which human beings, loved and cherished by God, love and cherish God in return; salvation consists essentially in being loved by God and loving God in return, and through that love entering into the divine life itself.

Charity therefore anticipates eschatological consummation. It grants, in via, a real though imperfect sharing in divine beatitude, ordered toward the perfect participation that is heaven. The claim that love of neighbour participates in divine love presupposes this ontological transformation: one loves as friend of God because one has been drawn into God’s own loving life.⁴⁸

The contrast with Aristotle sharpens Aquinas’ originality. For Aristotle, friendship requires a certain equality; the radical disproportion between gods and humans rendered divine–human friendship impossible.⁴⁹ Aquinas does not deny the infinite ontological distance; rather, he insists that grace has overcome it. In charity, God becomes the person’s friend, and the person — infinitely distant by nature — becomes God’s friend by grace.⁵⁰ The Aristotelian framework is thus perfected from within. Friendship with God is not merely conceivable but the most perfecting possibility open to the human person and the key to beatitude.⁵¹

The possibility of such friendship rests entirely upon grace. Aquinas describes grace as the *dilectio* by which God not only esteems but chooses and singles out the creature so that it may share in divine goodness (ST I–II, q. 110, a. 1). Grace effects a “spiritual rebirth,” making the believer a new creation.⁵² It is not an impersonal elevation but the personal love of the Triune God drawing creatures into communion.

Eberhard Schockenhoff captures the theological depth of this vision: Aquinas’ God is not a remote unmoved mover but the God of love who seeks intimate community and companionship with human beings. Grace

48 Mary Ann Fatula, *Thomas Aquinas: Preacher and Friend* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1993), 161.

49 Daniel Schwartz, *Aquinas on Friendship* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2007), 1.

50 Eberhard Schockenhoff, ‘The Theological Virtue of Charity’, trans. Grant Kaplan and Frederick G. Lawrence, in *The Ethics of Aquinas*, ed. Stephen J. Pope (Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 2002), 246.

51 Paul J. Wadell, “Growing Together in the Divine Love,” in *Aquinas and Empowerment*, ed. G. Simon Harak (Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 1996), 148.

52 Paul J. Wadell, “An Itinerary to Glory,” *Studies in Christian Ethics* 23 (2010): 436.

thus establishes not only a new moral capacity but a new relational reality. The human person becomes capable of loving God with God's own love.⁵³

The Holy Spirit is central to this transformation. In ST II–II, q. 24, a. 2, Aquinas identifies the Spirit as the love of the Father and the Son, and also as their love for us. The same love that constitutes the divine life is poured into human hearts. Charity is therefore not simply directed toward God; it is participation in God's own self-love. In this sense, charity establishes a fellowship beyond anything envisioned by classical philosophy: it is communion in the very act by which the Trinity loves.⁵⁴

The divine–human friendship established by grace is concretely mediated in Christ. Aquinas argues in the *Summa contra Gentiles* that the Incarnation was fitting because friendship requires familiarity: since friendship involves a certain equality, it was helpful for greater familiarity that God became man.⁵⁵ The visible humanity of the Word becomes the means by which humanity ascends to the invisible God (ScG IV.54.2). The term *communicatio* thus acquires christological depth; the hypostatic union is the supreme instance of divine self-sharing (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1).

The Passion is the apex of this communicative love. Aquinas treats the Cross under the headings of satisfaction, merit, and exemplar. Objectively, Christ's obedient love restores justice for the human race: humanity is set free by Christ's justice (ST III, q. 46, a. 1). Yet the same article underscores divine mercy: God gave his Son out of "exceeding charity" (Eph 2:4). The Passion reveals the unity of Father and Son in willing salvation. It is an icon of Trinitarian love enacted in history.

Subjectively, the Cross provokes charity in the believer. Aquinas states that one fitting reason for Christ's suffering is that the human person may know how much God loves him or her and thus be moved to love God in return (Rom 5:8; ST III, q. 46, a. 3). Daria Spezzano has shown how Aquinas interweaves objective causality and subjective transformation: the Passion forgives sins instrumentally and simultaneously stirs charity in the believer.⁵⁶ Earlier figures such as Peter Lombard, and perhaps Abelard, had already invoked Romans 5:8 to suggest that the sight of

53 Schockenhoff, "The Theological Virtue of Charity," 248.

54 Young, *The Politics of Praise*, 135.

55 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa contra Gentiles* IV.54.6. Hereafter ScG.

56 Daria Spezzano, "Be Imitators of God" (Eph 5:1): Aquinas on Charity and Satisfaction," *Nova et Vetera* 15 (2017): 627.

God’s charity kindles reciprocal love.⁵⁷ Aquinas deepens this tradition by integrating it into his doctrine of infused virtue. The Cross becomes the greatest “friendly deed,” one that safeguards and increases friendship (ST I–II, q. 82, a. 2).

Christ is therefore both cause and exemplar. His charitable obedience restores justice and manifests the Father’s goodness, eliciting sorrow for sin, joy in deliverance, and imitation.⁵⁸ Charity, working through the virtue of religion, produces devotion because love moves one to serve one’s friend (ST I–II, q. 82, a. 2). Meditation on the Passion becomes the principal stimulus to such devotion.

3.5. Love of Neighbor “in God”

If charity is friendship with God, its implications for love of neighbor follow necessarily. Aquinas treats this under the *ordo caritatis*. Because charity is structured by participation in God, it possesses intrinsic order. God must be loved above all as the ultimate end (ST II–II, q. 25, a. 1). Neighbor is loved not competitively but in relation to God, as one ordered to the same beatitude.

Aquinas states: “We ought to love our neighbor out of charity, inasmuch as he is ordered to God” (ST II–II, q. 25, a. 1). The friendship of charity extends to all who belong to God or are capable of belonging to God (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1). The object of charity is God primarily and neighbors secondarily, but under one formal aspect: participation in divine beatitude.

This structure is decisive for understanding the unity of divine and neighbor-love. Love of neighbor is not secondary in the sense of dispensable. It is intrinsic to friendship with God (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1). As Stephen Pope emphasizes, divine friendship is expansive; it includes those whom God loves. One cannot claim friendship with God while rejecting those whom God wills to save.⁵⁹

Aquinas formulates the principle that neighbor is loved *propter Deum* — for the sake of God. This does not imply instrumentalization. Rather, it situates love within its ultimate horizon. The formal reason for loving neighbor is participation in God. Charity enables the believer to perceive

57 Ibid., 631n62.

58 Ibid., 651.

59 Stephen J. Pope, “The Order of Love and Recent Catholic Ethics: A Constructive Proposal,” *Theological Studies* 52 (1991): 258.

others as sharers in the same divine calling.⁶⁰

In ST II–II, q. 25, a. 6, Aquinas clarifies that sinners are loved not because of their sin but because of their nature and capacity for grace. Friendship entails willing the good of the other for the other's sake. Charity radicalizes this by harmonizing the will with God's own willing. The friend of God loves what God loves and hates what God hates (ST II–II, q. 104, a. 4). Thus, love of neighbor flows from conformity to the divine will (ST I–II, q. 19, a. 10).

Nicholas Healy notes that this structure preserves authentic reciprocity.⁶¹ The neighbor is not merely object of obligation but co-participant in divine life. Love is concrete, directed toward the flourishing of the other in God.

Aquinas' identification of charity as friendship with God is doctrinally exact. Charity is the theological virtue by which the human person participates in the life of the Trinity. It is grounded in grace (ST II–II, q. 24, aa. 2–3), sustained by participation (ST I–II, q. 112, a. 1), structured by reciprocity (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 1), and oriented toward beatitude (ST I–II, q. 62, a. 1).

The equality required for friendship, as Aristotle insists, (NE 8.7 [1158b]). is impossible between Creator and creature on natural terms. Aquinas resolves this not by denying inequality but by introducing participation (ST I–II, q. 112, a. 1). God elevates the human person to a supernatural plane. As William Young explains, divine initiative establishes a derivative equality.⁶²

Aquinas grounds the order of charity in the teleological constitution of reality. Love, as an appetite directed toward apprehended goodness, is intrinsically ordered: some goods are perceived as more proportioned or nearer to the agent than others. This hierarchy reflects divine wisdom rather than subjective preference. As Aquinas states, "Grace and virtue imitate the order of nature, which is set up out of divine wisdom" (ST II–II, q. 31, a. 3). The natural inclinations of the will — toward self, kin, fellow citizens, and others — are not opposed to charity but minister to it.⁶³

60 Young, *The Politics of Praise*, 120.

61 Nicholas M. Healy, *Thomas Aquinas: Theologian of the Christian Life* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2003), 127. Cf. ST II–II, q. 23.a. 2.

62 Young, *The Politics of Praise*, 102.

63 Stephen J. Pope, "The Moral Centrality of Natural Priorities: A Thomistic Alternative to 'Equal

This teleological account resists any abstract theory of "equal regard" that would treat partiality as morally suspect. Stephen J. Pope underscores that for Aquinas the partial structure of love reflects divine providence: "the explicitly partial nature of love and of our natural moral priorities is seen to reflect, not merely 'idiosyncratic preferences,' but the providential will of the Creator as expressed in the ordering of creation."⁶⁴ The natural *ordo amoris* thus serves as both condition and instrument for attaining the higher order of charity. Far from dissolving concrete attachments, supernatural love perfects them.⁶⁵

Aquinas' psychological realism reinforces this structure. He observes that a person "loves those closest to him [or her] and wills them good more intensely than those who are better and for whom he [or she] wills a greater good" (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 7). Intensity of affection corresponds to degrees of union; blood relations, as the most intimate natural bonds, evoke the strongest love (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 8). This gradation is proportionate to both object and agent: "Every action must be proportioned both to its object and to the agent producing it, the object furnishing its species, the power of the agent its degree of intensity" (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 7). The outward effects of charity therefore follow the pattern of natural inclination, just as in physical nature tendencies accord with the essence of things (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 6). Grace proportionates affection: "our affection for those towards whom we ought to show more kindness is more intense than it is for others" (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 6). Charity demands not equal affection but rightly ordered intensity.

This ordered structure reaches systematic expression in Aquinas' doctrine of the twofold order of charity: love according to nearness to God (*meliores*) and love according to proximity to oneself (*conjunctiores*). First, charity is founded upon friendship with God. God is loved above all as "the principle of eternal happiness, sharing of which is the basis of this divine friendship" (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 1). Among neighbors, those nearer to God by greater goodness are to be loved more: "Our neighbors are not all equally related to God. Some are nearer to Him by reason of their greater goodness, and those we ought, out of charity, to love more than those who are not so near Him" (ST II-II, q. 26, a. 6). This objective hierarchy

Regard," *The Annual of the Society of Christian Ethics* 10 (1990): 113.

64 Ibid., 113.

65 A. P. d'Entrèves, *Natural Law* (London: Hutchinson, 1970), 47-48.

mirrors divine love itself, which is proportioned to goodness (ST I, q. 20, aa. 3–4).

Second, love is ordered according to proximity to the self. Those united by blood, marriage, or friendship elicit greater intensity. Aquinas specifies this gradation with notable precision: father before children (ST II–II, q. 26, a. 9), father before mother (ST II–II, q. 26, a. 10), parents before spouse (ST II–II, q. 26, a. 11); friends are loved more than enemies (ST II–II, q. 27, a. 7); the virtuous more than the vicious, though friends may take precedence over the merely virtuous (ST II–II, q. 31, a. 3). One loves oneself above all except God (ST II–II, q. 26, aa. 3–4), yet the spiritual good of the neighbor surpasses one’s bodily good (ST II–II, q. 26, a. 5). Such distinctions do not fragment charity but articulate its rational coherence.

Charity, in Aquinas’ formulation, conforms the human person to God “by making man comport himself towards what is his, as God does toward what is His” (ST II–II, q. 27, a. 2). As friendship with God, charity entails participation in the divine manner of loving. It infuses new qualities — joy, peace, mercy (ST II–II, qq. 27–33) — while preserving the providential ordering embedded in creation. Preferential regard is therefore not an exception to charity but an expression of it. Angels, benefactors, the poor, and the needy all find their place within the *ordo amoris* (ST II–II, q. 25, a. 11; q. 26, a. 12; qq. 30 – 32). The Christian loves in a new way, yet always within an ordered hierarchy reflecting divine wisdom.

Because charity is friendship with God, it functions as the principle and norm of the entire Christian life. It is “the principle of religion,” operating through acts of worship so that the believer may adhere to God (ST I–II, q. 82, a. 2). As friendship increases through friendly deeds, so divine friendship is deepened through conformity to Christ’s self-giving love. The Passion, the supreme act of divine friendship, shapes the believer’s affective and moral life.

Contemplation of Christ’s self-offering produces sorrow for sin and joy in divine loving-kindness, nourishing devotion (ST II–II, q. 83, aa. 3–4). Charity both causes and is strengthened by such devotion. Human love for God is always a response to prior divine love; human love for neighbour is love for one whom God has befriended.

In this Thomistic architecture, charity is not beyond friendship but its

highest form: founded upon the surest *communicatio* of the highest good, initiated by divine love, and reciprocated through grace. Because the Christian loves as participant in Trinitarian communion, love of neighbour is not ancillary but intrinsic to divine friendship.⁶⁶ The love that unites Father and Son is the same love poured into human hearts and manifested in concrete acts. Thus, the structure of Aquinas’ doctrine of charity provides the theological foundation for affirming that to love those whom God befriends — especially in their vulnerability — is to love God himself.

3.6. The Order of Charity and Moral Priority

Aquinas’ account of love for the poor must be read within his doctrine of the *ordo caritatis* (ST II–II, q. 26). The natural and supernatural dimensions of charity are not opposed but integrated. Human beings exist within networks of kinship and dependence that generate specific obligations. Accordingly, Aquinas teaches that almsgiving is meritorious when it observes the order of love, which requires that “other things being equal, we should, in preference, help those who are more closely connected with us” (ST II–II, q. 26, a. 7). Family, friendship, and civic bonds carry genuine moral weight.

The order of charity therefore guards against a generosity that would undermine justice. One who follows the evangelical counsel to sell all and give alms sins if doing so harms dependents (ST II–II, q. 32, a. 6). Charity never authorizes the neglect of those entrusted to one’s care. The order of love ensures that zeal for the needy does not become moral disorder.

At the same time, Aquinas affirms that urgent necessity can outweigh special connection. Failure to meet the grave needs of another person — including a stranger — when one is able to do so constitutes a mortal sin (ST II–II, q. 32, a. 5).

3.7. Mercy (*Misericordia*) as the Form of Divine Love

Mercy (*misericordia*) occupies a central place in Aquinas’ theology of charity. He defines mercy as the act of charity by which one befriends a suffering neighbor and does what one can to assist (ST II–II, q. 30, a. 1). The heart is moved at the sight of another’s distress; the suffering of another draws one outward in response.⁶⁷

⁶⁶ Canary, “Transforming Friendship,” 13.

⁶⁷ Paul J. Wadell, “An Itinerary to Glory: How Grace is Embodied in the Communion of Charity,” *Studies in Christian Ethics* 23 (2010): 446.

Theologically, this movement is grounded in charity's transformation of perception. Aquinas writes that "sadness or pain are feelings aroused by evils afflicting a man's own self, and so sadness over another's misfortune is measured by the extent to which we see another's misfortune as our own" (ST II-II, q. 30, a. 2). Charity enables precisely this identification. Through its lens, others are no longer strangers but neighbors — indeed, "another self," fellow friends of God welcomed into the fellowship of charity (ST II-II, q. 25, a. 4).

Because charity unites believers in communion, another's suffering can be apprehended as one's own. Grief becomes shared, and action follows. Mercy is therefore integral to love of God: it is the form that love assumes when confronted with misery. Aquinas accordingly names mercy the greatest of the virtues and the one by which we most resemble God (ST II-II, q. 30, a. 4). In loving the afflicted, the friend of God conforms to the divine manner of loving.

Charity also entails habitual readiness: "even though a man is not actually doing good to someone, charity requires him to be prepared to do so if the occasion arises, and whoever the person in need may be" (ST II-II, q. 25, a. 5). This disposition creates a community marked by solidarity and mutual entrustment. Almsgiving, though associated with spiritual works of mercy, necessarily includes concern for bodily needs. Aquinas cannot conceive of authentic friendship with God that ignores the corporeal deprivation of neighbors. Through almsgiving, God provides for others through us; friends of God become instruments of divine compassion (ST II-II, q. 32, a. 1).

According to Aquinas, the participation in divine friendship gives rise to internal acts of benevolence and, where circumstances permit, to external acts of beneficence (ST II-II, q. 27, a. 2). Charity is therefore not exhausted by interior goodwill but seeks embodiment in concrete action. Love as friendship implies willing the good of the other and, when possible, acting for that good. The interior movement of charity is ordered toward effective assistance.

In this context, Aquinas defines alms as acts of beneficence "whereby something is given to the needy, out of compassion and for God's sake" (ST II-II, q. 32, a. 1). Almsgiving thus arises simultaneously from affective

compassion and theological intention. The act is performed *propter Deum* — for God’s sake — and therefore participates in divine friendship. Corporal works of mercy are not undertaken in expectation of reciprocity or temporal reward from God (ST II–II, q. 32, a. 5); rather, they manifest the gratuitousness proper to charity.

3.8. Preferential Care and the Proportionality of Divine Love

Aquinas’ metaphysical account of divine love clarifies the theological meaning of preferential care. Compassion flows from God’s love and is displayed when God dispels the misery of the afflicted (ST I, q. 21, a. 3). Yet love and care must be carefully distinguished.⁶⁸ Aquinas illustrates this with the example of a master who expends more resources on expensive medicine for a sick servant than on his healthy son (ST I, q. 20, a. 3). The greater expenditure does not signify greater love for the servant; it reflects the demands of the servant’s need (ST I, q. 21, a. 3). The degree of care is not identical with the degree of love (ST I, q. 20, a. 3).

This distinction illumines Aquinas’ position regarding the poor. God may be said to have a special “love” for the poor insofar as divine mercy is proportionate to need — a benevolent response to suffering. Yet this does not imply that God loves the poor more than others with respect to the ultimate union willed for all. Human conditions are mutable; superiority in one respect may coexist with inferiority in another (ST I, q. 20, a. 3; ST II–II, q. 31, a. 2). Preferential care therefore expresses responsiveness to need rather than a hierarchy of intrinsic worth.

Within this Thomistic horizon, love of the poor emerges as participation in the divine movement by which God’s simple and eternal love assumes concrete, merciful form in the relief of misery. Charity as friendship with God unites the believer to the divine love that is both universal and proportionate. To love the poor is thus not to depart from the love of God but to enact it in its merciful intensity.

Conclusion

Dilexi Te affirms with theological clarity that “love of the poor is love of God.” When viewed through the complementary perspectives of liberation theology and Thomistic charity (*caritas*), this statement displays a deep

68 Stephen J. Pope, “Proper and Improper Partiality and The Preferential Option for The Poor,” *Theological Studies* 54 (1993): 262.

inner consistency. Liberation theology highlights the tangible, historical dimension of God's love, while Aquinas supplies its metaphysical grounding. Combined, they show that care for the poor is not simply charitable giving or a political tactic, but a true sharing in God's own life.

In liberation theology, the preferential option for the poor expresses the historical and structural demands of God's revelation. The poor represent the primary place where God reveals Himself and where belief turns into active practice. This preference goes beyond acts of compassion; it involves standing in solidarity and prompting conversion within the Church. The poor are not just passive beneficiaries of aid — they are active theological participants and drivers of history. Loving them embodies the lived faith in the crucified and risen Christ, who emptied Himself by becoming poor.

Aquinas, by contrast, roots this love in the metaphysics of participation and the virtue of charity. *Caritas* is a form of friendship with God, an infused sharing in the love of the Trinity. From this divine friendship, love for others naturally flows in an ordered way. In Thomistic thought, priority for the poor stems not from social theory but from the internal logic of mercy within the hierarchy of love (*ordo caritatis*). Those with the greatest need deserve more immediate help because charity corresponds the human will with God's merciful will. Thus, this preferential concern is anchored in the nature of virtue and the priority of divine happiness.

A real distinction appears here. For Aquinas, preferential love is chiefly a matter of moral and theological order: it involves rightly directing charity to meet needs within a structured hierarchy of love. Liberation theology, however, gives this preferential love a clear historical and socio-political edge: it directly challenges injustice, identifies oppression, and demands systemic change. Aquinas stresses sharing in divine life inwardly through grace; liberation theology stresses sharing in historical processes of liberation outwardly. The first is centered on the inner framework of grace; the second draws out its communal and institutional implications.

This distinction, though, is not opposition but genuine growth. Liberation theology deepens and extends elements already present in Thomistic *caritas*. If charity truly means friendship with God, and if God reveals Himself through self-emptying solidarity with the poor, then sharing in that friendship must take concrete, historical shape. The God who

offers beatitude is the same God who “became poor.” Therefore, the metaphysical participation Aquinas describes inevitably leads toward real-world solidarity.

DT positions itself exactly at this convergence. It reaffirms the Thomistic principle that love of neighbor springs from friendship with God, while fully incorporating liberation theology’s call for that love to be tangible, structural, and liberating. The document avoids reducing charity to mere activism or confining preferential love to personal piety. Instead, it integrates both in a Christ-centered perspective: the poor serve as a sacramental sign of the One who declares, “I have loved you.”

Loving the poor, therefore, means joining in God’s self-emptying movement (*kenosis*); it means responding to the divine invitation to friendship; it means uniting one’s will with Christ’s compassionate heart. The preferential option is not something added onto faith from outside — it is faith’s own historical embodiment in charity. In this light, the Church’s longstanding teaching on *caritas* and its modern emphasis on the option for the poor meet in one unified theological reality: love for the poor is love for God, because it participates in the very love with which God has first loved us.

Fr. Dr. Gigesh Meckal is a priest of the Ranchi province belonging to the Third Order Regular of St. Francis of Assisi (TOR). He teaches subjects such as Fundamental Moral Theology, Theology of Justice, Theology of Sin and Reconciliation, Theology of Marriage and Sexuality, Christian Virtues, Contextual Theology, and Tribal Theology at various theological institutes in India. He has published several works and presented papers at both national and international conferences, most recently at the 60th Annual Conference of Societas Ethica held at Uppsala University in August 2024. He preaches retreats and conducts workshops for laity, religious, priests, teachers, and students. He can be reached at +91 91022 20422 or via email at jjeshstor@gmail.com.